The *Kamasutra* advises the nagaraka to live in a big city if possible. On getting up in the morning, the book tells us, the nagaraka should have an oil-massage, bathe, shave, apply perfumes and, most importantly, clean the sweat from his armpits (the author is quite insistent on this). After lunch, he should entertain himself by teaching his parrot to talk, or by attending a cock-fight or ram-fight. Then, after a nap, it was time to dress up and head for the salon. The *Kamasutra* tells us that the evenings would be full of music, singing and drink. By late evening, the nagaraka and his friends would withdraw to a private room, decorated with flowers, where women could rendezvous with them. The courtesans are colourfully described as 'women who love all men equally'. They would share wines and spirits made of grapes, honey and sugarcane. The *Kamasutra* advises the men to engage the women in 'gentle conversation and courtesies that charm the mind and the heart'. Presumably the evening did not end just in conversation.

Picnics too are described in the same way. The men would get ready early in the morning and head for the countryside on horseback accompanied by friends, servants and courtesans. They would while the day away in gambling, cock-fights and theatrical performances. In the summer, the picnickers would enjoy water-sports in specially built pools designed to keep crocodiles out (very sensible in my view; it can really spoil your day to have a limb bitten off while frolicking in the pool with the ladies).

The *Kamasutra*'s description of the lifestyle of a fourth-century man-about-town is fascinating, and finds an echo in much later periods. The lives of the idle nawabs of nineteenth-century Lucknow and the Bengali zamindars of early-twentieth-century Kolkata have been common themes in literature and film, but some of these characters would have not been out of place if they had been transported back fifteen centuries to imperial Pataliputra. Like other aspects of Indian culture, this tradition too lives on in the world of 'Page 3' socialites in cities like Delhi and Mumbai.

So what did all these people and their world really look like? Despite the long passage of time, we have carvings and paintings that give us a visual insight into this world in the Ajanta and Ellora caves in Maharashtra. These